

Neuromarketing at the Shelf

A field guide for FMCG brands: how the shopper brain actually chooses, and how to design packaging, pricing and placement for it.



The two-second decision

The average supermarket carries over 30,000 SKUs. Shoppers do not compare them — the brain filters them, using shortcuts built long before your brand existed. Shelf decisions happen in under two seconds, mostly below conscious awareness.

Eye-tracking studies consistently show that placement within the first visual sweep captures 70% of initial fixations. If your pack blends into category codes, you are paying shelf fees to be invisible.



Fluency beats novelty

The brain rewards what it can process quickly. Familiar structures with one distinctive disruption — a colour break, a shape, a face — outperform radical redesigns in almost every repeat-purchase category.

Rule of thumb: revolution is for launch campaigns; evolution is for packs. Identify your untouchable memory structures before touching anything.



Price is a perception

Anchoring, decoy options and unit framing routinely move willingness-to-pay by double digits without changing the product. A premium tier can lift total category revenue simply by making the mid tier feel sensible.

Test price architecture with behavioural methods — stated willingness-to-pay in surveys overstates and misleads.



Testing that predicts

Ask shoppers what they think of a pack and they will tell you what they think they think.

Measure instead: eye-tracking for attention, implicit association testing for memory structures, shelf-context tests for findability.

Benchmark: strong packs achieve identification in under two seconds at three metres in a cluttered shelf context.



The field checklist

1. Map your memory structures before any redesign. 2. Test packs in shelf context, never in isolation. 3. Measure attention before recall. 4. Frame price against an anchor, not in a vacuum. 5. Treat every touchpoint — pack, shelf, feed — as one behavioural system.

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